conquering the world. You will be much taken aback, I guess,' wrote Fanny to her sister in England, 'when they march hand in hand and take Motcombe.'[15]

That night Fanny sat next to Ranjit Singh at the banquet and was intrigued and charmed by her dining companion. He had turned up in a pair of plain white kurta pyjamas, with one single jewel, the Koh-i-Nur, glinting on his arm – not perhaps the most tactful ornament for the occasion, given how he had come to own it. The Sikh monarch spent much of the evening trying to get Fanny to drink his home brew. 'The composition he calls wine is like burning fire, and much stronger than brandy,' she noted afterwards.

> At first he was content to let George and Sir W Cotton swallow it. Then he began plying me with gold cupfuls. I got on very well for some time, pretending to drink it and pass it to his cupbearer. But he grew suspicious, put it up to his one eye, looked well into the cup, shook his head and gave it back to me again. The next time he put his finger into the cup to see how much had gone. I made Major Wade explain that ladies do not drink so much in England, upon which he waited until George's head was turned away and passed a cup to me under his arm, thinking George was a horrid tyrant who prevented me.[16]

George meanwhile was fending off persistent questions from his new colleague about why he did not possess even one wife. 'George said that only one was allowed in England,' reported Emily, 'and if she turned out a bad one, he could not easily get rid of her. Runjeet said that was a bad custom; that the Sikhs were allowed twenty-five wives, and they did not dare to be bad, because he could beat them if they were. G replied that was an excellent custom, and he would try to introduce it when he got home.'

The next morning the Sikhs showed off their drill and impressed their allies with their discipline and particularly with the accuracy of their artillery. Then it was the turn of the British. 'The consummate skill with which the British chief attacked an imaginary enemy', wrote Kaye, 'was equalled by the gallantry with which he defeated it. He fought indeed a great battle on the plain, and only wanted another army in his front to render his victory a complete one.'[17]

Two days later, after further displays of military and equestrian prowess, many more speeches and several more banquets, the troops finally set off to war. Led forward by lancers with scarlet cloaks and plumed shakos, the columns of cavalry and infantry regiments headed downstream towards